



Morals and Dogma and the “Lucifer Hoax”

*Excerpt from Albert Pike’s **Morals & Dogma**, Annotated Edition
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While the authors of *Morals and Dogma for the 21st Century* make innocent mistakes, and the motives of Knight and Lomas are less clear, there are unambiguous enemies of Freemasonry which are true offenders. Such an example is Ron Carlson, an anti-Masonic preacher from Minnesota, who elevated Pike’s text to the level of scripture by alleging that “*Morals and Dogma* is the Bible of the Masons.” Carlson compounds his error by asserting that Pike is “the number one authority which all Masons look to.” These are claims which neither Pike nor the Scottish Rite have ever made. On the contrary, Pike’s original preface to *Morals and Dogma* clearly stated:

The teachings of these Readings are not sacramental, so far as they go beyond the realm of Morality into those of other domains of Thought and Truth. The Ancient and Accepted Scottish Rite uses the word “Dogma” in its true sense, of doctrine, or teaching; and is not dogmatic in the odious sense of that term. Everyone is entirely free to reject and dissent from whatsoever herein may seem to him to be untrue or unsound. It is only required of him that he shall weigh what is taught and give it fair hearing and unprejudiced judgment. Of course, the ancient theosophic and philosophic speculations are not embodied as part of the doctrines of the Rite; but because it is of interest and profit to know what the Ancient Intellect thought upon these subjects.

Clearly, this is not the way to introduce an authoritative work of any kind, much less a “Bible.” However, elevating the status of *Morals and Dogma* is imperative to the anti-Mason who wishes to misuse its text for a given argument. Although a study of anti-Masonry is beyond the scope of this work, numerous examples of such abuse have been previously exposed.¹ For now, one example will suffice. Certain critics of Freemasonry allege a “Luciferian” influence in the Scottish Rite, which they attribute to Albert Pike. In support of this, critics sometimes cite the following from *Morals and Dogma*, which is largely extracted from Lévi’s *History of Magic* (1860), can be seen below:

Morals and Dogma

The Apocalypse is, to those who receive the nineteenth Degree, the Apotheosis of that Sublime Faith which aspires to God alone and despises all the pomps and works of Lucifer. LUCIFER, the *Light- bearer*! Strange and mysterious name to give to the Spirit of Darkness! Lucifer, the Son of the Morning! Is it *he* who bears the *Light*, and with its splendor’s intolerable blinds feeble, sensual, or selfish Souls? Doubt it not! for traditions are full of Divine Revelations and Inspirations
(*M&D*, 19:28)

Éliphas Lévi, *History of Magic*

...what can such solution signify to the faith which aspires only to God, which despises the pomps and works of Lucifer?

Lucifer—Light bearer—how strange a name, attributed to the spirit of darkness! Is it he who carries the light and yet blinds feeble souls? The answer is yes, unquestionably; for traditions are full of divine disclosures and revelations.

(p. 36)

This passage is easily misunderstood when not read carefully, and just as easily understood if read carefully. Let us break it down into two parts: (1) *Morals and Dogma* states that *the Apocalypse (Book of Revelation), the last book of the New Testament, is the “apotheosis” (ideal example) of faith which aspires to God and rejects the works of Lucifer*. Clearly, the passage states that the Biblical book of Revelation is an example to the righteous; (2) It then adds that “*Lucifer*” is a strange name to give to the spirit of darkness who uses “light” to mislead weak and selfish people. But why does it say that “Lucifer, the light-bearer” is a strange name for the spirit of darkness? Simply because the name Lucifer *means* “light-bearer.” The name derives from the Latin genitive *lucis* (light) and *ferre* (to bring *or* to bear); hence *lucis-ferre* becomes *Lucifer*, the “light bearer.” It is thus ironic that the “spirit of darkness” should be called “light bearer.” The notion that the Adversary uses light to deceive people was accepted by the Apostle Paul, who wrote that Satan disguises himself as an angel of light (2 Cor. 11:14), and this scripture may have helped connect the Adversary with the name Lucifer.

¹ de Hoyos and Morris, *Is It True What They Say About Freemasonry?* (2010)

Lucifer, Son of the Morning

But why is Lucifer called “the Son of the Morning?” This alludes to older translations of Isaiah 14:12 (e.g. KJV), which read, “How art thou fallen from heaven, O Lucifer, son of the morning!” According to Biblical commentators this verse is actually a condemnation of an ancient king of Babylon, who had persecuted the Israelites, and does not refer to the devil at all.²

The original Hebrew verse calls the Babylonian king *helel, ben shachar* (הִלֵּל בֶּן־שָׁחַר), meaning “Day Star, son of dawn.” The word *helel*, “day star,” was a title for the planet Venus³ which is second nearest the sun. Isaiah’s language evokes the image of the Babylonian king, filled with pride. The Latin Vulgate Bible also used “Lucifer” in this verse⁴ as the name of the planet Venus, as a metaphor of the King of Babylon, who would likewise “fall” as the planet apparently does. Isaiah’s chapter includes a prophecy of his downfall. The Vulgate’s translation of *helel* as “Lucifer” was not an error; both the Hebrew and the Latin words mean the planet Venus. Additional strong evidence that the word *Lucifer* does *not* mean “the devil,” appears in the New Testament. The Latin text of 2 Peter 1:19 actually uses the name Lucifer for Jesus, calling Him “the day star” who will “arise in your hearts” (*lucifer oriatur in cordibus vestris*), while Revelation 22:16 also calls Jesus “the bright and morning star,” which is another allusion to the same planet. Clearly, Biblical allusions to the planet Venus are merely used to evoke an image of the star’s brightness and glory. Fortunately, modern Bible translations frequently include detailed notes which explain and preserve the original context of these and many other difficult passages.

Although some early Christians, including Tertullian (*Contra Marcionem*, 11, 17), considered Lucifer an appellation of Satan, the Adversary, John Milton’s *Paradise Lost* (1667) helped establish the common notion of Lucifer-as-the-devil which prevails in much of the English-speaking Christian world today. Indeed, the theology of Milton’s epic work colors common notions about Biblical theology. *Paradise Lost* not only relates to how Adam and Eve were expelled from the Garden of Eden, but develops the story of Lucifer, an angel cast out of heaven with his followers. He becomes Satan, the Adversary of God and enemy of man’s salvation. Angered at being cast from heaven he and his followers strive to lead the man Adam and his posterity astray.

² John Wesley’s *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (1754–65), notes, “Lucifer—Which properly is a bright star, that ushers in the morning; but is here metaphorically taken for the mighty king of Babylon.”

³ The Hebrew *helel* was translated into the Greek Old Testament (i.e., the Septuagint) as *Eosporos* (Ἑωσφόρος), which is a similar personification of the planet Venus.

⁴ “Quomodo cecidisti de calo, Lucifer, qui mane oriebaris? corruisti in terram, qui vulnerabas gentes?” (How art thou fallen from heaven, O Lucifer, who didst rise in the morning? how art thou fallen to the earth, that didst wound the nations?)

Morals and Dogma 19:28 is also sometimes mentioned together with the “Léo Taxil hoax,”⁵ a known forgery which asserted that Albert Pike and Scottish Rite Masons worship Lucifer as their god. This notorious hoax was created soon after Pike’s death when Léo Taxil⁶ declared that Albert Pike was the “Sovereign Pontiff”(!) of Freemasonry, ruling over a secret body called the Palladium. According to the hoax, Pike delivered instructions to “The 23 Supreme Confederated Councils of the world” (no such organization actually existed). The instructions included the statement “Yes, Lucifer is God,” with the further assertion that Adonai, the God of the Bible, is the evil god.

In spite of its patent absurdity, the hoax was accepted by the Roman Catholic Church for many years, and Freemasons were denounced as Luciferians and devil-worshippers. Taxil’s hoax was eventually uncovered, and he made a full and public confession which was published in contemporary newspapers;⁷ the hoax is now officially rejected by the Catholic Church.⁸ In spite of this, anti-Masons continually use this false witness against the Fraternity.

⁵ For detailed studies of the hoax, as well as the complete text of Taxil’s published confession, see “Léo Taxil: The Hoax of ‘Luciferian Masonry,’” in de Hoyos and Morris, *Is It True What They Say About Freemasonry?* (2010), 23–41, 195–228.

⁶ “Léo Taxil” was the penname of the ribald French journalist Marie Joseph Gabriel Jogand-Pages (1854–1907). In addition to anti-Masonic works, he wrote pornography and anti-Catholic literature.

⁷ Taxil’s confession was published in *Le Frondeur* (Paris, April 25, 1897), and was translated into English for the first time by Alain Bernheim, A. William Samii, and Eric Serejski as “The Confession of Léo Taxil” (1996): 137–68.

⁸ For a brief recital of Taxil’s “pretended exposures of the practices of Freemasonry, and particularly of the ‘Satanisme’ or Devil-worship,” see Herbert Thurston, “Impostors,” in *The Catholic Encyclopedia* (New York: Robert Appleton Company, 1910), 7:703.